# MUSIC 140-Lecture 12 - With Extended Commentary

Hard Rock / Heavy Metal

Shift to the "Hippie Aesthetic"

- started by The Beatles' *Sgt. Peppers*
- marks the shift from "Rock 'n' Roll" to "Rock" - moving from:
    - singles to albums o dancing to listening
    - entertainers to "serious" musicians
- sonic development from Psychedelic Blues / British Blues Revival
- to a great extent it is a response to the failure of Counter Culture
- The philosophy of the counter culture was more focused on the advantages of the collective. With the shootings at Kent State, the philosophy of the collective began to give way to more of a focus on the individual.

While the lyrics and themes of Hard Rock / Heavy Metal are quite different from those of the counter culture, it was very much made possible by the changes that take place in the late 1960s – particularly those connected with The Beatles and the shift to the 'Hippie Aesthetic." This new style would be very much focused on albums and listening rather than singles and dancing. And there will be a significant focus on artistry and musicianship. The sound of HR/HM will be influenced by important elements of the mid to late 1960s such as Psychedelic Blues (Jimi Hendrix) and the British Blues Revival, but there will be differences in terms of how the influences are found. However, in terms of lyrics and themes, HR/HM is very much a response to the failure of the counter-culture turning away from the collective to focus on the individual. The events of the 1970s discussed above, will push culture even more towards the individual.

Hard Rock and Heavy Metal are often considered two different styles and there are significant distinctions. But it makes more sense to consider them as extremes of a continuum (HR at one end, HM at the other). Some bands will be clearly rooted in one end or the other, but many bands will fall in-between, exhibiting characteristics from both ends of the scale. Also, the characteristics will evolve over time and so a group that may have been considered HM at one time, may now be considered HR because of more recent stylistic changes.
So, if we put the two styles on a scale, what will distinguish one end from the other?

**Distinctions between Hard Rock and Heavy Metal:**

1/ The sound of the distorted electric guitar is central to both, but Heavy Metal tends to have a much higher level of distortion, and distortion is found not just in the guitar, but the bass and even the vocals.

2/ In keeping with the "Hippie Aesthetic" both styles put an emphasis on the technical ability of the musicians, however Heavy Metal tends to be more concerned with complex musicianship.
Hard Rock songs are often performed at "mid-tempo." While they still fall into what we have been describing as the "Hippie Aesthetic" and are intended for listening, Hard Rock songs are often at a good tempo for dancing; not too slow, not too fast. However, Heavy Metal songs are often at extremely fast or slow tempos which make more of a show of the technique of the musicians (it's harder to play really slowly or really quickly).
Hard Rock often used basic musical structures such as Verse/Chorus and 12-Bar Blues, while Heavy Metal would often use longer, more complex structures that often had a similarity to those of classical music.

3/ At the Hard Rock end of the scale there is a much more pronounced influence of blues. In part, this is due to the origin of the style. As we sill see, many of the early bands emerged from the British Blues Revival, and Psychedelic Blues is considered an important precursor. The blues influence may be heard in song structures, approaches to guitar solos and riffs, and vocal style. But as we move to the Heavy Metal end of the scale, the blues influences become harder to hear and there is more of a focus on complex technique and musicianship (see point 2 above). One of the influences is western classical music. We hear this in more complex musical structures, changes of tempo, highly coordinated ensemble playing and virtuosic guitar solos.

4/ Hard Rock lyrics often fall into the Chuck Berry traditions of girls, cars, no school, and rock and roll. Heavy Metal lyrics often deal with elements of fantasy, religion, and darker psychological states such as paranoia and insanity. Alienation and loss of control are also common themes in Metal. The futility and horror of war is often used as a symbol of these feelings. Both are reflective of the shift from community focus to the focus on the individual. In the first case, forgetting your problems and just having a good time. In the second case, a feeling that the problems are overwhelming.

Before we look at the founding bands of the style, let's briefly look at two bands that nicely illustrate the ends of the spectrum:

Example: AC/DC (Hard Rock) - Australian, formed in 1973.
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gEPmA3USJdI
- the album "Back In Black" (1980) has sold over 50 million copies, 2nd highest album sales in history. - strong blues influence, steady tempos, rock 'n' roll lyrics.

An excellent example of a hard rock band is Australia's AC/DC. Watch the YouTube video of AC/DC performing 'Highway To Hell."
Notice that despite the title, this is a song about life on the road for a rock band, and are very much in the tradition of Chuck Berry.
Notice that once the song starts, it is based on a guitar riff (blues influence). The tempo is steady and not too fast. When the guitar solo starts at 2:47, notice how guitarist Angus Young briefly does a physical move called the "duck-walk' (2:47-2:49). This is a move associated with Chuck Berry.

Example: Metallica (Heavy Metal) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2f1Ny74_ou0 - Los Angeles, formed in 1981.
- musically highly technical, frequent tempo changes, instrumental sections, classical influences, virtuosic soloing, heavy distortion, lyrics that express alienation and loss of control.

Watch the YouTube video of Metallica performing 'Master Of Puppets.'
Notice the lyrics in this song are focused on a loss of control – the feeling that one is helpless against the forces of the world.
The song has multiple contrasting sections including ensemble instrumental work (for examples see 3:44 or 5:57) and virtuosic soloing (5:25). The song goes through several major changes of feel and tempo changing from quite fast to quite slow. The instrumental parts are highly technical.
This is an excellent example of Heavy Metal, in terms of lyric themes, and focus on complex musicianship.

Founding Bands
1/ Black Sabbath
2/ Deep Purple
3/ Led Zeppelin

Black Sabbath: - British

- "doomy music"
- madness / futility of war

"War Pigs" (1970 – from the album *Paranoid*)

- tempo changes
- instrumental sections
- lyrics that focus on alienation, futility
- but lower level of distortion

While there are many bands who helped to develop the sound of HR/HM, most historians tend to focus on three British bands that appear in the late 1960s: Black Sabbath, Deep Purple and Led Zeppelin. Part of the reason why the style first develops in Britain may be that British culture did not experience the counterculture in the same way as the US. It spends much of the 1950s rebuilding after WWII and by the mid 1960s the British economy was already falling into recession. There was no post-war prosperity experienced by British youth. This may be why their bands turned away from the collective ideals of the counterculture before American bands did.

Let's have a brief look at each band and see how they use the elements of HR/HM. Remember as we go through the examples that we are not trying to decide if each band is HR or HM. What we are doing is looking at how all three have elements of both – but the elements will change from one band to the next.

Our first band is Black Sabbath. Singer Ozzie Osborn has discussed how British youth of the late 1960s did not feel the same level of optimism that their north American counterparts were experiencing. He states that the bands were trying to capture this sense of 'doom' that was felt by the British audience.

Listen to Black Sabbath's 'War Pigs'

Notice that the song has a high number of section and tempo changes. There are numerous instrumental sections included a drum solo quite early in the song. The lyrics deal with a loss of control and the futility of war. All are characteristics that are associates with Heavy Metal.

There is one way in which Black Sabbath does lean back towards the Hard Rock end of the scale. Osborn's voice does not have a high level of distortion (unlike many singers in this style). In fact, his voice is one of the most recognizable in HR/HM because of Osborn's clearer, often more nasal vocal tone.

Deep Purple:

- also British

"Highway Star" (1972 – from the album *Machine Head*) - "Berry-style" lyrics

- virtuosic vocal performance during the introduction
- use of electric organ (Jon Lord)
- classical influences in musicianship and approach to solos

Another important early band was Deep Purple. In many ways, DP was like BS with its layout of vocal, guitar, bass, and drums, but there was a key difference: keyboardist Jon Lord. Most rock guitarists tend to be self taught, but keyboardists often have years of formal lessons which expose them to the works of classical European composers. Because he had extensive training in classical music, Jon Lord could bring the classical traditions of composition and technicality to the band's work. He is one of the musicians who integrate classical traditions into Hard Rock/Heavy Metal.

Listen to Deep Purple's 'Highway Star.'

Notice that in many ways this song seems closer to the Hard Rock end of the spectrum. The lyrics (Nobody's gonna take my car…Nobody's gonna take my girl) are very much in the tradition of Chuck Berry. And while the song does have several different sections, the tempo remains steady – not too slow, not too fast. However, there is a high level of distortion including in the vocal performance. And there are 'virtuosic' elements of performance such as the vocals in the introduction. Also, listen to the keyboard solo starting at 2:14. Lord plays a quick, almost mathematical series of notes. Anyone with experience in classical music will recognize this precise, patterned approach as being influenced by classical music – in this case the music of the European Baroque era (Bach, Vivaldi). This highly technical approach to soloing with become an important element for all musicians in the style, particularly when we reach the HM end of the spectrum.

Led Zeppelin:

- once again, also British…
- grew out of The Yardbirds (British Blues Revival)
- significant blues influence
- also strong acoustic / Celtic influence
- virtuosic musicianship / mastery of recording studio
- no interest in "editing" for singles

"Whole Lotta Love" (1969 – from the album *Led Zeppelin II)*

- blues-riff-based
- middle section similar to 'psychedelic' approach of counter culture.
- sued by Willie Dixon of Chess Records ("You Need Love"

1962 – performed by Muddy Waters)

The final of our three bands is Led Zeppelin. They are by far the hardest to pin down simply because of the range of things they did. The band had its origins in the British Blues Revival. Guitarist Jimmy Page had recently joined a group call The Yardbirds. The Yardbirds were an important Blues Revival group that featured guitarists such as Eric Clapton. Shortly after Page joined, the band decided to break up. Page, left without work, continued on with a new temporary group named The New Yardbirds, simply to give himself time to find something else long term. But the new group did so well that they decided to stay together and changed their name to Led Zeppelin.

Because of their roots in the Blues Revival, Led Zeppelin always had a strong blues influence in their work. But even early on, the group was experimenting with a more acoustic celtic/folk-influenced sound and Jimmy Page (influenced by The Beatles) would become fascinated by the potential of the recording studio. Also in keeping with the 'Hippie Aesthetic' the band had no interest in shortening their songs to fit the requirements of singles for hit radio, even when refusing to do so could potentially cost the band significant income. First and foremost, they were focused on albums.

Listen to Led Zeppelin's "Whole Lotta' Love."
This song is an excellent example of both the influence of blues and the growing fascination with creative use of the recording studio.
The song was actually a reworked version of a Muddy Waters' song called "You Need Love" composed by Chess Records' Willie Dixon. Indeed, the LZ version is so close to the original that Dixon successfully sued the group for royalties and writing credit in the early 1980s.

The song is riff-based, and Robert Plant's vocal approach is similar to Muddy Waters. Plant is just singing in a higher range. Given that the song is a reworked version of Willie Dixon's song, the lyrics are clearly in the tradition of blues.
But at 1:18, the nature of the song changes radically. Rather than a straight forward, blues-influences sound, the recording becomes experimental – almost abstract. This is a good example of the overlap between HR and HM and the music of the counter culture. This middle section can be described as 'psychedelic.' Now, some of you may get grumpy thing: 'Hey didn't you say that counter culture was separate from NR/HM?" In general yes, but like most points of cultural change, the later style is always influenced by the earlier style even if the later style ends up rejecting many of the earlier style's values.

The style may be viewed as a response to the failure of counter culture and a rejection of the collective ideal. With the collapse of the counter culture and a growing sense cynicism due to the major events of the 1970s, Hard Rock/Heavy Metal became an expression of the dissatisfaction that many young people had with the state of society. The Hard Rock end of the spectrum reflected a desire to ignore the problems and simply focus on pleasure, while Heavy Metal was an outwards reflection of youths' fears and pessimism. However, the style also offered a solution to the problem. Rather than focus on the collective, this is a style that focuses on the greatness of the individual: musical greatness, fame and financial success. To this end the bands create images that have a great deal in common with corporations. Most corporations have singular names ('Sony' or 'Apple' not 'The Sonys' or 'The Apples') The names of bands in HR/HM are often singular (Black Sabbath, Led Zeppelin, AC/DC, Kiss, Aerosmith) as opposed to plural, collective names of the 1960s (The Beatles, The Beach Boys, The Rolling Stones). They made use of (and continue to make use of) logos, similar to corporations, that remain consistent throughout their careers.

They became a model of success for their fans who often imagine themselves as part of the band.

## The Origins of Hip Hop

Hip Hop:

- folk culture
- South Bronx, New York City – 1970s
- Rap / Break Dancing / Graffiti Art

By the early 1970s, predominantly black inner-city neighborhoods were suffering. Following the civil unrest of the mid to late 1960s, many within black urban communities who had achieved a middle-class standard of living had moved

to the suburbs leaving only working-class families, and the poor. This had a serious impact on local economy and standard of living for those who remained. Such was the case in the Bronx neighborhood of New York City. To make things worse, in 1972, the Cross Bronx Expressway was completed, meaning the whole neighborhood could now be avoided except for those who lived there. Local standards of living collapsed.

However, the young people of the area still wished to find ways of artistic expression. Like Great Britain after World War II, the youth of the Bronx adopted a folk-like, Do-ItYourself (DIY) approach to creating culture. In the world of dance we see the development of Break Dancing. In visual art, the technique of Graffiti Art takes shape. And while music lessons and instruments were too expensive for most, there was access to other resources and a technique of creating new music using records, turntables and the human voice began to take shape. This was the origin of Rap.

**Precursors:**

1/ Signifying / The Dozens

- Oral word game
- Ritualized insulting
- African origin

**Example: "Signifyin' Monkey"**

While we have spent much of the term focusing on the importance of sound and articulation within African American music, the use of words as an aesthetic/expressive medium is also an important characteristic with its origins in West-African culture.

One example of this is "Signifyin'" or "Playing The Dozens" which involves both a type of poetic story-telling as well as a form of ritualized contest of insulting your opponent.

Note that the performance, recorded in the early 1960s, lacks any type of rhythmic accompaniment, but many of the elements of Hip Hop are here: speed, improvisation, rhyming, and creativity are highly valued.

2/ Jamaican Toasting

- yard dances / Sound system men/DeeJay
- SSM become 1st Jamaican recording producers
- Producing for Yard Dances
- Same song on both sides, one without vocals - Toasting
- SSM would vocally improvise over the "B" side.

While there are several important precursors to the development of Hip Hop, perhaps the most important was a style of playing records at dances that was imported from Jamaica. Jamaica has long been one of the poorest regions in the western hemisphere. Few owned a record player, and while radios were more common, local radio stations were controlled by the BBC and rarely played anything that could be considered "popular" music. However, radios could occasionally pick up American radio playing R&B and Rock 'n' Roll. Both styles were popular with those who heard them.
Sound System men were Jamaican DJs who would stage large outdoor parties. Much of their popularity was based on acquiring American music, and eventually they began to produce their own records for use at Yard Parties. While one side of the record would feature the song, the other would feature a "remix" without most of the vocals. The Sound System Men would put on the second side and begin to talk on the microphone, often talking about how wonderful they were, and how much better their parties were as compared to their competitors. This became known as Toasting.

**Prehistory:**

1973, Kool Herc
- two turntables
- extends exciting moments of a song – "breaks"
- the 'Merry-Go-Round."
- "cutting and mixing"
- toasting

We first see the Jamaican practice appear in the US in 1973. During the late 1960s and early 1970s, increasing numbers of Jamaicans move to the US, many of whom settle in New York. Clive Campbell A young man who went by the name Kool Herc was a Jamaican immigrant who begins to hold Jamaican Yard Dance style events on the streets of the Bronx. He uses two turntables to extend the most exciting parts of a song, becoming the first person we know of to "recompose" a song using a turntable. He described this technique as 'the merry-go-round.' He also engaged in Jamaican-style toasting. When asked what he was doing with the two turntables, Herc described the technique as "cutting and mixing."

1976, Grand Master Flash

- Develops Kool Herc's techniques
- "quick mix"

By 1976, Grand Master Flash had developed a much faster version of Herc's technique. Employing the practice of "backspinning" a record, Flash was able to better control the music, and mix two records together over only a few seconds. He described this as the "Quick Mix." He also appears to be the first DJ to master the technique of 'backspinning' or using his hand to rapidly spin a record backwards by a short predetermined amount to repeat a short phrase

1976, Grand Master Melle Mel

- toaster/rapper for Grand Master Flash
- first to describe himself as an 'MC' or Master of Ceremonies.
- does "full length" raps
- writes them down

Because of the attention that was required to do the Quick Mix technique, Flash was unable to do his own toasting, and so began to work with several rappers including Grand Master Melle Mel. Mel is credited with several innovations, including being the first to describe himself as an MC or Master of Ceremonies, as well as being the first rapper to write down his verses and perform them in a consistent manner, as opposed to improvising them each time. This would make Mel the first "songwriter" in Hip Hop.

1978, Grand Wizard Theodore

- scratching
- redefining technology of the turntable.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zRzIyuXCIPw
For those who are interested, here is a short and more recent video of Theodore at work.

Although there is some debate, Grand Wizard Theodore is generally credited with the invention of "scratching," a technique in which the DJ manually manipulates the record to create sound, rather than allowing the record to play as intended. With this technique, Theodore completes the process of redefining the technology of the turntable from one of consumption to production. As a technology of consumption, the turntable is used to play a record as intended. Your role is simply to consume the recording. But in Theodore's hands, the turntable becomes a technology of production. It is used to create something new, like a musical instrument.

1st recorded hit song.

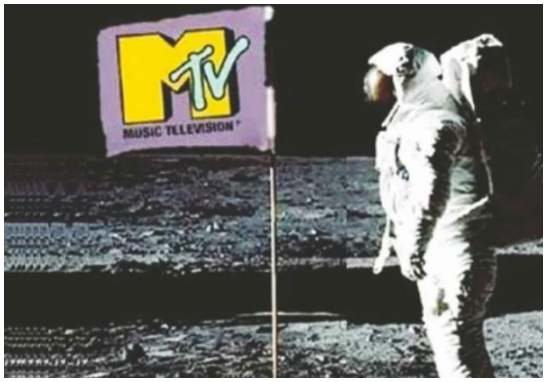
- Sugar Hill Gang: “Rapper’s Delight”
- Released 09/79; #4 RnB, #36 Pop
- Based on the song “Good Times” by Chic (6/79, #1 Pop and RnB)

**EXAMPLE: “ Rapper’s Delight” (The Sugar Hill Gang, 1979)**

By 1979, this style had become very popular within the South Bronx, but was still largely unknown outside this small part of New York City. Some local record producers had considered recording some rap, but it was not until the end of that year that Sylvia Robinson, a minor soul star from the 1960s and owner of a local record label called Sugar Hill Records, produced the song “Rapper’s Delight.” Featuring three local rappers, the lyrics were rapped over music based on the most popular song of the year, a disco hit called “Good Times” by Chic
Listen to a bit of the original version of ‘Good Times.’ https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Er9xGRolrT4

Now listen to ‘Rapper’s Delight’

Notice one of the first lines of lyrics: “Now what you hear is not a test, I’m rappin’ to the beat.”
Think about that. It is the end of 1979 and if you don’t live in New York City (and a small region of New York City at that) you don’t know why he’s talking…why is he talking? Because he is not testing the microphone, he’s rapping.




- August 1981: MTV is on the air…

Rap Excluded from MTV until 1985-1986, “Walk This Way” Run DMC/Aerosmith

**Example: “Walk This Way” (Run DMC/Aerosmith, 1986)**

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4B_UYYPb-Gk (Video for 1986 version)

Over the first half of the 1980s, Rap grew in popularity with younger black audiences, but was largely rejected by white fans of older styles such as Rock and even older black audiences who preferred soul and funk. Nevertheless, it may have had a broader impact except that 18 months after the release of “Rapper’s Delight’ the music industry experienced a huge change. MTV, the first 24-hour music-video station began broadcasting in the summer of 1981. For the first time, fans had access to music videos, 24 hours a day. At first, the music industry dismissed MTV, but by the end of 1981, it was obvious that “high-rotation” on MTV was rapidly becoming the most influential source of hit records. By 1982, exposure on MTV was central to a successful career. However, the founders of MTV were largely white and middle-class. The station had a clear bias towards a white rock and pop audience but featured little coverage of early Rap videos in its programming. In fact, all black artists found they had a harder time having videos put into rotation including Michael Jackson. Given how important MTV had become in generating and promoting hit songs, this was a significant problem.

But in 1985, Hip-Hop artists Run DMC collaborated with 1970s’ stadium-rock stars Aerosmith to produce a Hip Hop version of the rock band’s 1977 hit, “Walk This Way.” The original 1977 recording featured a drum intro that had long been popular among Hip Hop DJs.

Listen to the beginning of the original 1977 version of “Walk This Way.’

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4c8O2n1Gfto

Listen (and watch the video) for the 1986 version. Compare the audio from the Hip Hop version to the original. Also, have a look at the video. It’s a wonderful depiction of attitudes at the time. At first, the two bands practicing side by side seem to have no understanding of what the other is doing. But by the end, they have (literally) broken down the wall and combined their efforts.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4B_UYYPb-Gk (Video for 1986 version)

THE END…